

The Bottleneck Calculator

Is your problem a people problem, a tool problem, a technology problem, an SOP problem or a policy problem?

Use this before hiring another person, buying another tool or adding another process. It helps you find where the work is actually getting stuck.

Includes a diagnostic scorecard + worked example + bottleneck cost calculator

Start with the bottleneck, not the solution

A slow team does not automatically mean you need more staff. A repeated mistake does not automatically mean you need new software. The visible problem and the real cause are often different.

This tool separates five common causes:

Possible cause	What it means
People / capacity	There is too much work for the available time, or the work needs skills the team does not currently have.
Tool	The team is missing a simple practical tool, template, checklist, tracker or shared place to work.
Technology	The work could be automated, connected or handled better by software.
SOP	The right process is not written down clearly enough for people to repeat it consistently. SOP means Standard Operating Procedure: the agreed steps for doing a task.
Policy	People do not know the rule, limit, authority or standard they are expected to follow.

Part 1: Diagnose the problem

Score each statement from 0 to 3. Use what is actually happening, not what you think should be happening.

0 = No • 1 = Sometimes • 2 = Often • 3 = Very often

Area	Statement	Score 0–3
People / capacity	Work is delayed even when the process and expectations are clear.	_____
People / capacity	The same people are overloaded week after week.	_____
People / capacity	Important work needs skills or experience the team does not currently have.	_____
Tool	People rebuild the same documents, trackers or checklists repeatedly.	_____
Tool	Information is hard to find or spread across too many places.	_____
Tool	A simple shared template or tracker would remove repeated manual work.	_____
Technology	People repeatedly copy, paste, enter or move the same information.	_____
Technology	Two or more systems need the same information but do not talk to each other.	_____
Technology	A large amount of time is spent on predictable digital tasks.	_____
SOP	Different people complete the same task in different ways.	_____
SOP	Work depends on someone remembering the next step.	_____
SOP	Mistakes happen because the handoff or sequence is unclear.	_____
Policy	Work waits because nobody knows who can approve or decide.	_____
Policy	People repeatedly ask what is allowed, required or expected.	_____
Policy	The same judgement call is being made differently by different people.	_____

Part 2: Find the strongest signal

Add the three scores in each area. Each category has a maximum score of 9.

Area	Your total	What a high score suggests
People / capacity	___ / 9	Check workload, role design, skills and staffing.
Tool	___ / 9	Try a simpler shared tool before buying complex software.
Technology	___ / 9	Look for automation, integration or better software.
SOP	___ / 9	Write, test and train a repeatable process.
Policy	___ / 9	Clarify rules, authority, limits and decision rights.

How to read the result

The highest score is where to investigate first, not an automatic diagnosis. Two high scores can be connected. For example, a weak SOP can make a team look understaffed because people spend time correcting avoidable mistakes.

Before spending money, test the cheapest reasonable fix and measure whether the bottleneck changes.

Part 3: What is the bottleneck costing you?

Use this quick calculator for repeated delays or wasted work. Estimates are fine. The point is to make the size of the problem visible.

Input	What to enter	Your number
People affected	How many people regularly lose time because of this bottleneck?	_____
Time lost each	Average hours lost per person each week.	_____ hours
Hourly cost	Approximate cost of one working hour for the people affected.	\$ _____
Weeks per month	Use 4.33 for a monthly estimate.	4.33

Monthly bottleneck cost

People affected × hours lost each week × hourly cost × 4.33 = estimated monthly cost

Estimated monthly cost: \$ _____

This is a simple time-cost estimate. It does not include lost sales, customer delays, rework, missed opportunities or the cost of mistakes.

Worked example

A marketing team keeps missing approval dates. The first reaction is: “We need another account manager.” The team uses the diagnostic before hiring.

Area	Score	What they found
People / capacity	4 / 9	Busy, but workload alone does not explain the delays.
Tool	3 / 9	The current tracker is basic but usable.
Technology	2 / 9	Automation could help later, but it is not the main block.
SOP	8 / 9	The approval steps change depending on who is working on the job.
Policy	9 / 9	Nobody is clear about which work needs senior approval and who has the final say.

What they try first

Instead of hiring immediately, they define approval authority, create one short approval SOP and test it for four weeks. If delays remain after the process is clear, they reassess capacity.

Example cost

If 5 people lose 2 hours each week and their average working-hour cost is \$25:

$$5 \times 2 \times \$25 \times 4.33 = \$1,082.50 \text{ per month}$$

Part 4: Choose the smallest useful fix

Do not solve a \$1,000 problem with a \$20,000 system. Start with the smallest change that can test your diagnosis.

If the signal is...	Test first	Then consider
People / capacity	Rebalance workload; remove low-value work; check skills gaps.	Hiring, outsourcing or role changes.
Tool	Create one shared template, tracker or checklist.	A dedicated tool if the simple version works.
Technology	Map the repeated manual steps.	Automation, integrations or new software.
SOP	Write the current best process in simple steps and test it.	Training, ownership and regular updates.
Policy	Write who can decide what, plus the rule and limits.	Approval matrices, governance or wider policy changes.

Your next test

The bottleneck we think we have: _____

The evidence: _____

The smallest fix we will test: _____

Who owns the test: _____

How long we will test it: _____

What should improve if we are right: _____

Find the block before you buy the fix.

Mulberry & Reed • Tell a good story. Make it stick. Leave a mark.